

Department of Political Science,
Digital Democracy

Syllabus

Political Persuasion in a Digital Reality

Seminar instructor

Cathrine Valentin Kjær, Lecturer

E-Mail: Cathrine.kjaer@ipz.uzh.ch

Office: H-343

Office Hours: Wednesdays 15.00-16.00

Seminar time and location

Wednesday, 12.15-14.00

Room: F-150

Fall term

Diversity Statement

You, as the participants of this class, are diverse in many ways. Diversity can refer to ways that you identify yourselves, including but not limited to gender, sexuality, disability, age, socioeconomic status, ethnicity, race, and culture. The diversity you bring to the class is viewed as a resource, strength, and benefit.

In this class, I want to promote diversity, not only because it fuels excellence and innovation but also because I want to assure everyone that their contributions to the class are encouraged and appreciated. Your diversity is fundamental to building and maintaining an equitable and inclusive classroom atmosphere and community.

Please let me know ways to improve the effectiveness of the course for you personally or for other students or student groups.

Definitions: Many terms in this document are mainly used in an academic context. Here you find a list of the definitions for these terms. Please look them up using this resource if they are unfamiliar to you.

Information on the Use of AI tools: The use of generative AI (artificial intelligence) in assignments is permitted for the purpose of copy-editing and to support coding tasks (e.g. in R). All other uses are prohibited. Please note that IPZ has issued a new declaration of authenticity where the use of AI tools must be clearly stated; you are required to use this new form when submitting your final assignment for this class. If you have questions about the use of AI tools in this seminar, please contact me. Please remember that the sole responsibility for the correctness of all content rests with you when you submit your final assignments.

Accommodation for disadvantages: Students who live with disadvantages or chronic illnesses that affect their studies are entitled to accommodation for disadvantages. This adapts the general conditions for you during the examination, for example, you are granted more time. These decisions are not made by the individual lecturer but by the University's Disability Office. You should apply for such accommodation in good time. You can find more information here.

Please consider the following websites and hotlines:

- If you have questions about financing your studies, please contact the Students Financial Aid Office.
- If you think you have experienced discrimination on account of your sex, gender identity, or sexual orientation, please contact the Office for Gender Equality and Diversity.
- Do you think you or someone else has been affected by sexual harassment? Please consult the information on this website: Protection Against Sexual Harassment.

- Are you experiencing personal problems or are you facing important decisions? Please consider psychological counselling, you find all information here.
- Do you need to talk to someone in confidence and anonymity (German or English)? Please consider nightline.ch, open from 20-24h daily via chat, email, or phone (provided by the student organisations of UZH and ETHZ).
- You find an overview of UZH student advisory services here.

Course description

When influencers engage in political discussions, do they influence the political attitudes of their followers? And if so, what mechanisms drive such influence? Understanding political persuasion, who influences whom, and how, is central to understanding how political opinions are formed and has long been studied in political science. However, in an era of digital media, the landscape of political communication has changed, and new types of actors are increasingly important in the media diet of ordinary people. But how should we understand these actors and their political influence? And how does political influence operate in this new digital reality? These are some of the questions we try to answer in this course.

To do so, we move through two parts. The first part covers the classical literature on political persuasion, examining the persuasive power of parties, friends, social groups, the media, and non-traditional sources of influence such as reality TV and celebrities. The second part asks how political persuasion changes in a digital reality. We do so by examining the structural characteristics that distinguish digital environments from traditional political arenas, discussing how information abundance, algorithmic curation, and interactivity change the conditions under which political influence operates. We conclude by turning to contemporary digital actors, such as influencers, YouTubers, and streamers, actors that exist primarily in a digital context, and ask whether the theories introduced throughout the course adequately capture their political influence.

The course concludes with a term paper and oral presentation in which students examine a phenomenon of political persuasion in digital environments. This may include a contemporary digital actor, a structural characteristic of digital platforms, or another topic discussed during the course. Drawing on the theories and concepts introduced throughout the seminar, students identify an unresolved theoretical or empirical question and develop an empirical research design to address it.

Learning goals

- Students will develop a strong understanding of the classical theories of political persuasion and the mechanisms through which political influence operates.
- Students will be able to critically evaluate how the structural characteristics of digital environments change the conditions under which political influence operates.
- Students will be able to assess the extent to which existing theories of political persuasion provide

an adequate framework for understanding contemporary digital actors and other forms of political influence in digital environments.

- Students will gain experience engaging with research from political behaviour, political communication, and computational social science.
- Students will be able to identify an original research question and develop an empirical research design related to political persuasion in digital environments.

Course Requirements

The course ends with a term paper and an oral presentation. Please note that the course will only be considered passed if both graded components are passed and the discussant role is completed.

Oral presentation (20% of grade)

In groups of two, students present an idea for the term paper during the final seminar sessions. The presentation should motivate the research question, outline the theoretical argument and the relevant literature, and explain the proposed empirical research design.

Presentations should be approximately 10 minutes, followed by questions and discussion with the discussants, fellow students, and the instructor. Students are expected to demonstrate a thorough understanding of their research idea and to respond to questions and feedback concerning their theoretical argument, methodological choices, and proposed empirical strategy.

Slides must be uploaded one week before the presentation, so that the discussants have a chance to familiarise themselves with the material.

Discussant (compulsory, not graded)

Each group is assigned to act as discussants for another group's presentation. The role of the discussants is to prepare and deliver comments on the presentation. Please familiarise yourself with the slides beforehand and prepare comments and questions for the presenters. While you can prepare questions in advance, not all information will be in the slides, so be ready to adjust if your original questions are addressed during the presentation. The group has 3 minutes in total, so the intervention should be to the point, constructive, and aimed at clarifying or advancing the ideas presented.

Term paper (80% of grade)

Building on their presentation, students prepare a term paper in the form of an empirical research design. The paper is due on **Friday, 8 January 2027 (23:59)**.

The core task is to identify an unresolved theoretical or empirical question that arises from the fact that political influence today operates in digital environments, that is, a question that existing theories of political persuasion cannot fully answer because the structural characteristics of digital platforms change the conditions under which influence operates.

The topic may be freely chosen but should fall within the substantive areas covered in the seminar. This may include a contemporary digital actor (e.g., influencers, streamers, content creators, or politicians), a characteristic of digital platforms (e.g., algorithmic curation, moderation, or interactive communication), or another topic discussed during the course. Drawing on the theories and concepts introduced throughout the seminar, students should propose a research question and develop an empirical research design capable of addressing it.

The final paper should include:

- a clearly formulated research question;
- a discussion of the relevant literature and theoretical framework;
- a justification of the research gap and expected contribution;
- a detailed empirical research design, including appropriate data and methods; and
- a discussion of the feasibility and limitations of the proposed study.

The term paper may be written individually or, optionally, as a co-authored paper by a team of two students. Co-authored papers receive a single collective grade shared by both authors.
Further details on the expectations for the term paper will be provided in class.

OLAT/Online Platforms

Find the OLAT site here.

Program

Political persuasion

W1: Political persuasion: The big picture
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W2: Political parties and their influence
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W3: The history of media effects
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W4: Reality TV and celebrities
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W5: Friends, family, and political influence
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W6: Group identity and social norms
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

The digital reality

W7: Contemporary diagnoses of the digital space
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W8: The commercial logic of digital platforms
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W9: Information abundance and fragmented exposure
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W10: Information abundance: The role of curation
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W11: Interactive digital environments and social influence
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

W12: Modern digital actors and their role in politics?
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150

Presentations

W13: Student presentations
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150
(Schedule announced separately.)

W14: Student presentations
Time: 12.15 – 14.00
Room: F-150
(Schedule announced separately.)

Weekly Program

Part 1: Classical theories of political persuasion

The first part of the course introduces the key arguments on political persuasion in political behaviour. We will examine actors traditionally seen as influential and explore the mechanisms behind their persuasive power.

Week 1 (Date: 16.09.2026): Political persuasion: The big picture

In this class, we draw on key theories of political behaviour to understand actors of political persuasion. However, the assigned readings suggest that political attitudes are remarkably stable and that direct persuasion attempts often have minimal effects. But if that is true, what room is left for political influence? And why do we still see shifts in political attitudes? We will discuss this and situate the course within the broader fields of political science and political communication.

Mandatory readings:

- Sears, David O., and Carolyn L. Funk. 1999. 'Evidence of the Long-Term Persistence of Adults' Political Predispositions'. *The Journal of Politics* 61(1): 1–28. doi:10.2307/2647773.
- Kalla, Joshua L., and David E. Broockman. 2018. 'The Minimal Persuasive Effects of Campaign Contact in General Elections: Evidence from 49 Field Experiments'. *American Political Science Review* 112(1): 148–66. doi:10.1017/S0003055417000363.

Optional readings:

- Achen, Christopher H. 1975. 'Mass Political Attitudes and the Survey Response'. *American Political Science Review* 69(4): 1218–31. doi:10.2307/1955282.
- Druckman, James N. 2022. 'A Framework for the Study of Persuasion'. *Annual Review of Political Science* 25: 65–88. doi:10.1146/annurev-polisci-051120-110428.

Week 2 (Date: 23.09.2026): Political parties and their influence

Thinking about political persuasion, one of the first actors that comes to mind is political parties. But how do parties influence people's attitudes? Some argue that parties provide informational shortcuts and cues, so that citizens do not have to rely on complex and detailed information to make sense of the world. Others argue that the persuasive power of parties lies not in information but in identity and the feeling of belonging to a group. The assigned readings present recent evidence on these two mechanisms.

Mandatory readings:

- Iyengar, Shanto, Gaurav Sood, and Yphtach Lelkes. 2012. 'Affect, Not Ideology: A Social Identity Perspective on Polarization'. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 76(3): 405–31. doi:10.1093/poq/nfs038.
- Barber, Michael, and Jeremy C. Pope. 2019. 'Does Party Trump Ideology? Disentangling Party and Ideology in America'. *American Political Science Review* 113(1): 38–54. doi:10.1017/S0003055418000795.
- Leeper, Thomas J., and Rune Slothuus. 2014. 'Political Parties, Motivated Reasoning, and Public Opinion Formation'. *Political Psychology* 35(S1): 129–156. doi:10.1111/pops.12164.

Optional readings:

- Tilley, James, and Sara B. Hobolt. 2011. 'Is the Government to Blame? An Experimental Test of How Partisanship Shapes Perceptions of Performance and Responsibility'. *The Journal of Politics* 73(2): 316–30. doi:10.1017/S0022381611000168.
- Lupia, Arthur. 1994. 'Shortcuts Versus Encyclopedias: Information and Voting Behavior in California Insurance Reform Elections'. *American Political Science Review* 88(1): 63–76. doi:10.2307/2944882.
- Taber, Charles S., and Milton Lodge. 2006. 'Motivated Skepticism in the Evaluation of Political Beliefs'. *American Journal of Political Science* 50(3): 755–69. doi:10.1111/j.1540-5907.2006.00214.x.
- Slothuus, Rune, and Martin Bisgaard. 2021. 'Party over Pocketbook? How Party Cues Influence Opinion When Citizens Have a Stake in Policy'. *American Political Science Review* 115(3): 1090–96. doi:10.1017/S0003055421000332.

Week 3 (Date: 30.09.2026): The history of media effects

Can the media change our minds? Or just direct our attention? Moreover, what power lies in the control of the agenda? And what about the fact that most people prefer entertainment over the news? These are some of the major discussions among media scholars. In this session, students will be introduced to the main arguments for and against the persuasive power of media, and to the mechanisms through which media may affect us. We will read chapters from Arceneaux Johnson (2013) and Kim (2025) to provide an overview.

Mandatory readings:

- Arceneaux, Kevin, and Martin Johnson. 2013. *Changing Minds or Changing Channels?: Partisan News in an Age of Choice*. University of Chicago Press, **Chapters 1, 2, and 8**.
- Kim, Eunji. 2025. *The American Mirage: How Reality TV Upholds the Myth of Meritocracy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, **Chapters 1 and 2**.

Optional readings:

- Zaller, John R. 1992. *The Nature and Origins of Mass Opinion*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, **Chapters 1, 3, and 11**. doi:10.1017/CBO9780511818691.
- McCombs, Maxwell E., and Donald L. Shaw. 1972. 'The Agenda-Setting Function of Mass Media'. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 36(2): 176–87. doi:10.1086/267990.
- Broockman, David E., and Joshua L. Kalla. 2025. 'Consuming Cross-Cutting Media Causes Learning and Moderates Attitudes: A Field Experiment with Fox News Viewers'. *The Journal of Politics* 87(1). doi:10.1086/730725.
- Coppock, Alexander, Seth J. Hill, and Lynn Vavreck. 2020. 'The Small Effects of Political Advertising Are Small Regardless of Context, Message, Sender, or Receiver: Evidence from 59 Real-Time Randomized Experiments'. *Science Advances* 6(36): eabc4046. doi:10.1126/sciadv.abc4046.

Week 4 (Date: 07.10.2026): Reality TV and celebrities

In this session, we focus on reality TV and celebrities. As discussed in the previous session, most people spend the majority of their media consumption on entertainment content. Building on this insight, we begin by examining reality TV's ability to convey political messages and affect public opinion, using chapters from Kim (2025) as the starting point for our discussion. In the second part of the session, we shift the focus to celebrities. Celebrities command large audiences and attract significant media attention, but how effective are they at mobilising these audiences for political purposes or affecting their political behaviour? What mechanisms lead people to trust a movie star or a singer on political issues? These questions will guide the discussion and readings for this session. We return to these questions in the final lecture of the course, when we ask whether the same mechanisms explain the influence of digital creators.

Mandatory readings:

- Alrababa'h, Ala', William Marble, Salma Mousa, and Alexandra A. Siegel. 2021. 'Can Exposure to Celebrities Reduce Prejudice? The Effect of Mohamed Salah on Islamophobic Behaviors and Attitudes'. *American Political Science Review* 115(4): 1111–28. doi:10.1017/S0003055421000423.
- Garthwaite, Craig, and Timothy J. Moore. 2013. 'Can Celebrity Endorsements Affect Political Outcomes? Evidence from the 2008 US Democratic Presidential Primary'. *The Journal of Law, Economics, and Organization* 29(2): 355–84. doi:10.1093/jleo/ewr031.
- Kim, Eunji. 2025. *The American Mirage: How Reality TV Upholds the Myth of Meritocracy.* Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, **Chapters 3 and 7**.

Optional readings:

- Kosenko, Kami A., Andrew R. Binder, and Ryan Hurley. 2016. 'Celebrity Influence and Identification: A Test of the Angelina Effect'. *Journal of Health Communication* 21(3): 318–26. doi:10.1080/10810730.2015.1064498.
- Jackson, David J., Anthony J. Nownes, and Thomas Norton. 2024. 'Taylor Swift as a Potential Celebrity Political Endorser'. *American Politics Research.* doi:10.1177/1532673X241269863.
- Horton, Donald, and R. Richard Wohl. 1956. 'Mass Communication and Para-Social Interaction'. *Psychiatry* 19(3): 215–29. doi:10.1080/00332747.1956.11023049.

Week 5 (Date: 14.10.2026): Friends, family, and political influence

Some argue that our friends, family, and people with whom we interact daily have more persuasive power than the media and parties. But what is the persuasive power of our friends? How do they influence us, and why? This will be the focus of the session. We will read a classic piece on the two-step flow of communication, together with two recent experiments on how political influence spreads within families.

Mandatory readings:

- Foos, Florian, and Eline A. de Rooij. 2017. 'All in the Family: Partisan Disagreement and Electoral Mobilization in Intimate Networks - A Spillover Experiment'. *American Journal of Political Science* 61(2): 289–304. doi:10.1111/ajps.12270.
- Katz, Elihu. 1957. 'The Two-Step Flow of Communication: An Up-To-Date Report on an Hypothesis'. *Public Opinion Quarterly* 21(1): 61–78. doi:10.1086/266687.
- Dahlgaard, Jens Olav. 2018. 'Trickle-Up Political Socialization: The Causal Effect on Turnout of Parents' Voter Turnout'. *American Political Science Review* 112(3): 698–705. doi:10.1017/S0003055418000059.

Optional readings:

- Lazarsfeld, Paul F., Bernard Berelson, and Hazel Gaudet. 1968. *The People's Choice: How the Voter Makes Up His Mind in a Presidential Campaign.* Columbia University Press, **Chapters 5 and 16**. doi:10.7312/laza93930.

Week 6 (Date: 21.10.2026): Group identity and social norms

The final actor we study in this part of the course is not a person but a collection of people: the group. Some of the forces shaping our attitudes may not come from any individual persuader at all, but from the groups we belong to and the norms they carry. But what exactly is the persuasive power of groups? Does this power belong to all groups or only to those we identify with? And through which mechanisms does it operate? In this session, we approach these questions through two theoretical lenses: social identity theory and the study of social norms.

Mandatory readings:

- Bicchieri, Cristina. 2017. *Norms in the Wild: How to Diagnose, Measure, and Change Social Norms*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, **Chapter 1**.
- Tajfel, Henri, and John C. Turner. 2004. 'The Social Identity Theory of Intergroup Behavior'. In *Political Psychology*, eds. John T. Jost and Jim Sidanius. New York: Psychology Press, 276–93. doi:10.4324/9780203505984-16.
- Bursztyn, Leonardo, Georgy Egorov, and Stefano Fiorin. 2020. 'From Extreme to Mainstream: The Erosion of Social Norms'. *American Economic Review* 110(11): 3522–48. doi:10.1257/aer.20171175.

Optional readings:

- Bicchieri, Cristina. 2005. *The Grammar of Society: The Nature and Dynamics of Social Norms*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. doi:10.1017/CBO9780511616037.
- Tajfel, Henri, and John Turner. 1979. 'An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict'. In *The Social Psychology of Intergroup Relations*, eds. William G. Austin and Stephen Worchel. Monterey, CA: Brooks/Cole Publishing, 33–47.
- Abrams, Dominic, and Michael A. Hogg, eds. 1990. *Social Identity Theory: Constructive and Critical Advances*. New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf, **Chapters 1 and 2**.
- Dinas, Elias, Sergi Martínez, and Vicente Valentim. 2024. 'Social Norm Change, Political Symbols, and Expression of Stigmatized Preferences'. *The Journal of Politics* 86(2): 488–506. doi:10.1086/726951.

Part 2: The digital reality: A new context for political persuasion

Most of the actors and processes we covered in Part 1 also act in digital spaces. However, digital spaces are different, so the mechanisms we have covered might not work the same. But how are digital spaces different? Are they just an extension of what we already know, or do they change key fundamentals? In this part of the course, we take a step back and look at the digital space more generally. We examine the structural characteristics that distinguish digital environments from traditional political arenas, and we discuss how information abundance, algorithmic curation, and interactivity change the conditions under which political influence operates. We end by turning to contemporary digital actors, such as influencers, YouTubers, and streamers, and ask whether the theories introduced throughout the course adequately capture their political influence.

Week 7 (Date: 28.10.2026): Contemporary diagnoses of the digital space

In this session, we introduce a set of different perspectives on the digital space. The texts are assigned in a deliberate order: we move from an early, optimistic diagnosis to more pessimistic and nuanced ones, and end with a text that asks whether we should speak of "the digital" as one thing at all. When reading, students are encouraged to reflect critically on which diagnoses they find most convincing. This discussion prepares the sessions that follow, where we examine the structural characteristics of digital environments one by one.

Mandatory readings:

- Diamond, Larry. 2010. 'Liberation Technology'. *Journal of Democracy* 21(3): 69–83. doi:10.1353/jod.0.0190.
- Sunstein, Cass R. 2017. *#Republic: Divided Democracy in the Age of Social Media*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, **Chapter 1**.
- Tucker, Joshua A., Yannis Theocharis, Margaret E. Roberts, and Pablo Barberá. 2017. 'From Liberation to Turmoil: Social Media and Democracy'. *Journal of Democracy* 28(4): 46–59. doi:10.1353/jod.2017.0064.
- Kaufmann, Mareile, and Julien Jeandesboz. 2016. 'Politics and "the Digital": From Singularity to Specificity'. *European Journal of Social Theory* 20(3): 309–28. doi:10.1177/1368431016677976.

Optional readings:

- van Dijck, José, Thomas Poell, and Martijn de Waal. 2018. *The Platform Society: Public Values in a Connective World*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, **Chapter 1**. doi:10.1093/oso/9780190889760.001.0001.
- Aradau, Claudia, and Tobias Blanke. 2022. *Algorithmic Reason: The New Government of Self and Other*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, **Chapter 1**. doi:10.1093/oso/9780192859624.001.0001.
- Persily, Nathaniel, and Joshua A. Tucker, eds. 2020. *Social Media and Democracy: The State of the Field, Prospects for Reform*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, **Introduction**. doi:10.1017/9781108890960.

Week 8 (Date: 04.11.2026): The commercial logic of digital platforms

In this session, we discuss the commercial logic of digital platforms, which is geared towards maximising the time users spend on them. This logic shapes the features of digital spaces, from Like buttons to recommendation systems, and sets the boundaries of the information environment itself by determining what content is permitted and what is removed. What does it mean for public debate when the information environment is governed by technology companies rather than journalistic editors?

Mandatory readings:

- Zuboff, Shoshana. 2019. *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*. New York: PublicAffairs, **Chapter 1**.
- Gillespie, Tarleton. 2018. *Custodians of the Internet: Platforms, Content Moderation, and the Hidden Decisions That Shape Social Media*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, **Chapter 1**.
- Adler-Nissen, Rebecca, and Tobias Liebetrau. 2026. 'Big Tech as World Makers: A Research Agenda for International Political Sociology'. *International Political Sociology* 20(3): olag021. doi:10.1093/ips/olag021.

Optional readings:

- Klonick, Kate. 2018. 'The New Governors: The People, Rules, and Processes Governing Online Speech'. *Harvard Law Review* 131(6): 1598–1670.
- Lessig, Lawrence. 2006. *Code: Version 2.0*. New York: Basic Books, **Chapter 1**.
- Suzor, Nicolas P. 2019. *Lawless: The Secret Rules That Govern Our Digital Lives*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, **Chapter 1**. doi:10.1017/9781108666428.

Week 9 (Date: 11.11.2026): Information abundance and fragmented exposure

A second structural difference concerns how information is produced. In digital spaces, production shifts from a one-to-many system, where information is broadcast from institutional media outlets, to a many-to-many system in which anyone can produce and distribute content. The result is information abundance, and with it, fragmented exposure: rather than a common information environment, individuals encounter increasingly personalised streams of content. A question often discussed is whether this fragmentation produces partisan echo chambers. The empirical evidence is more mixed than the popular debate suggests, and the assigned readings present some of this evidence.

Mandatory readings:

- Messing, Solomon, and Sean J. Westwood. 2014. 'Selective Exposure in the Age of Social Media: Endorsements Trump Partisan Source Affiliation When Selecting News Online'. *Communication Research* 41(8): 1042–63. doi:10.1177/0093650212466406.
- Bakshy, Eytan, Solomon Messing, and Lada A. Adamic. 2015. 'Exposure to Ideologically Diverse News and Opinion on Facebook'. *Science* 348(6239): 1130–32. doi:10.1126/science.aaa1160.
- Guess, Andrew M. 2021. '(Almost) Everything in Moderation: New Evidence on Americans' Online Media Diets'. *American Journal of Political Science* 65(4): 1007–22. doi:10.1111/ajps.12589.
- Green, Jon, Stefan McCabe, Sarah Shugars, Hanyu Chwe, Luke Horgan, Shuyang Cao, and David Lazer. 2025. 'Curation Bubbles'. *American Political Science Review* 119(4): 1704–22. doi:10.1017/S0003055424000984.

Optional readings:

- Nyhan, Brendan, Jaime Settle, Emily Thorson, et al. 2023. 'Like-Minded Sources on Facebook Are Prevalent but Not Polarizing'. *Nature* 620: 137–44. doi:10.1038/s41586-023-06297-w.
- Guess, Andrew, Brendan Nyhan, Benjamin Lyons, and Jason Reifler. 2018. 'Avoiding the Echo Chamber about Echo Chambers: Why Selective Exposure to Like-Minded Political News Is Less Prevalent than You Think'. Miami, FL: Knight Foundation.
- Wojcieszak, Magdalena, et al. 2022. 'Most Users Do Not Follow Political Elites on Twitter; Those Who Do Show Overwhelming Preferences for Ideological Congruity'. *Science Advances* 8(39): eabn9418. doi:10.1126/sciadv.abn9418.
- Gentzkow, Matthew, and Jesse M. Shapiro. 2011. 'Ideological Segregation Online and Offline'. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 126(4): 1799–1839. doi:10.1093/qje/qjr044.

Week 10 (Date: 18.11.2026): Information abundance: The role of curation

The abundance of information also transforms gatekeeping in the public sphere. In a system where almost anyone can publish, the central challenge is no longer gaining access to the public sphere but attracting attention within it. Being heard, rather than simply having a voice, becomes the scarce resource. This scarcity creates a need for curation, and on digital platforms, much of that curation is performed by recommendation systems. But what kinds of content do these algorithms prioritise, and can this affect political attitudes? The assigned readings examine the relationship between algorithmic curation and political attitudes, reaching different conclusions about its effects.

Mandatory readings:

- Huszár, Ferenc, Sofia Ira Ktena, Conor O'Brien, Luca Belli, Andrew Schlaikjer, and Moritz Hardt. 2022. 'Algorithmic Amplification of Politics on Twitter'. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 119(1): e2025334119. doi:10.1073/pnas.2025334119.
- Guess, Andrew M., et al. 2023. 'How Do Social Media Feed Algorithms Affect Attitudes and Behavior in an Election Campaign?' *Science* 381(6656): 398–404. doi:10.1126/science.abp9364.
- Gauthier, Germain, Roland Hodler, Philine Widmer, and Ekaterina Zhuravskaya. 2026. 'The Political Effects of X's Feed Algorithm'. *Nature* 652(8109): 416–23. doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10098-2.

Optional readings:

- Piccardi, Tiziano, Martin Saveski, Chenyan Jia, Jeffrey Hancock, Jeanne L. Tsai, and Michael S. Bernstein. 2025. 'Reranking Partisan Animosity in Algorithmic Social Media Feeds Alters Affective Polarization'. *Science* 390(6776): eadu5584. doi:10.1126/science.adu5584.
- Hosseinmardi, Homa, Amir Ghasemian, Miguel Rivera-Lanas, Manoel Horta Ribeiro, Robert West, and Duncan J. Watts. 2024. 'Causally Estimating the Effect of YouTube's Recommender System Using Counterfactual Bots'. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 121(8): e2313377121. doi:10.1073/pnas.2313377121.
- Robertson, Ronald E., Jon Green, Damian J. Ruck, Katherine Ognyanova, Christo Wilson, and David Lazer. 2023. 'Users Choose to Engage with More Partisan News than They Are Exposed to on Google Search'. *Nature* 618(7964): 342–48. doi:10.1038/s41586-023-06078-5.

Week 11 (Date: 25.11.2026): Interactive digital environments and social influence

A third structural difference concerns how information is received. Digital spaces not only allow everyone to post, but also to interact with posted content and with each other. In these environments, information consumption is inseparable from social interaction. Unlike in broadcast media, where influence flowed from sender to receiver in relative isolation, online messages are embedded in visible reactions from others: likes, reshares, and comments. The audience is always visible, and the meaning and reach of any message is co-constructed by it. But do these social cues actually matter for political influence? The assigned readings suggest a nuanced answer: social cues can move political behaviour, but their effect on attitudes is less clear.

Mandatory readings:

- Bond, Robert M., et al. 2012. 'A 61-Million-Person Experiment in Social Influence and Political Mobilization'. *Nature* 489(7415): 295–98. doi:10.1038/nature11421.
- Guess, Andrew M., et al. 2023. 'Reshares on Social Media Amplify Political News but Do Not Detectably Affect Beliefs or Opinions'. *Science* 381(6656): 404–08. doi:10.1126/science.add8424.
- Settle, Jaime E. 2018. *Frenemies: How Social Media Polarizes America*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, **Chapters 1 and 2**. doi:10.1017/9781108560573.

Optional readings:

- Salganik, Matthew J., Peter Sheridan Dodds, and Duncan J. Watts. 2006. 'Experimental Study of Inequality and Unpredictability in an Artificial Cultural Market'. *Science* 311(5762): 854–56. doi:10.1126/science.1121066.
- Muchnik, Lev, Sinan Aral, and Sean J. Taylor. 2013. 'Social Influence Bias: A Randomized Experiment'. *Science* 341(6146): 647–51. doi:10.1126/science.1240466.
- Munger, Kevin. 2017. 'Tweetment Effects on the Tweeted: Experimentally Reducing Racist Harassment'. *Political Behavior* 39(3): 629–49. doi:10.1007/s11109-016-9373-5.
- Brady, William J., Killian McLoughlin, Tuan N. Doan, and Molly J. Crockett. 2021. 'How Social Learning Amplifies Moral Outrage Expression in Online Social Networks'. *Science Advances* 7(33): eabe5641. doi:10.1126/sciadv.abe5641.

Week 12 (Date: 02.12.2026): Modern digital actors and their role in politics?

In this session, we try to gather the pieces. The focus will be on more contemporary actors, such as influencers, YouTubers, and streamers. These actors combine much of what we have covered: they command parasocial bonds like celebrities, act as opinion leaders like our friends and family, and operate under the algorithmic and interactive conditions of digital platforms. But do they actually influence the political attitudes of their followers? Using the insights from the previous sessions, students are encouraged to think critically about the theorisation of these modern digital actors. Do the arguments convince you? Would they apply to all types of digital actors?

Mandatory readings:

- Schmuck, Desirée, Melanie Hirsch, Anja Stevic, and Jörg Matthes. 2022. 'Politics – Simply Explained? How Influencers Affect Youth's Perceived Simplification of Politics, Political Cynicism, and Political Interest'. *The International Journal of Press/Politics* 27(3): 738–62. doi:10.1177/19401612221088987.
- Klüver, Heike. 2024. 'Social Influencers and Election Outcomes.' Comparative Political Studies: 00104140241306955. doi:10.1177/00104140241306955.

Optional readings:

- Kowert, Rachel, and Emory Daniel. 2021. 'The One-and-a-Half Sided Parasocial Relationship: The Curious Case of Live Streaming'. *Computers in Human Behavior Reports* 4: 100150. doi:10.1016/j.chbr.2021.100150.
- Dekoninck, Heleen, and Desirée Schmuck. 2022. 'The Mobilizing Power of Influencers for Pro-Environmental Behavior Intentions and Political Participation'. *Environmental Communication* 16(4): 458–72. doi:10.1080/17524032.2022.2027801.
- Chmel, Kirill, Eunji Kim, John Marshall, Tiffany Fisher-Love, and Nathaniel Lubin. 2025. 'How Social Media Creators Shape Mass Politics: A Field Experiment during the 2024 US Elections'. SSRN working paper. doi:10.2139/ssrn.5932534.

Student Presentations

Week 13 (Date: 09.12.2026): Student presentations

Week 14 (Date: 16.12.2026): Student presentations